

Chapter 42: Getting Handsy

Ning Fuyi slept for a very long time. When she woke up, she had already traveled thousands of miles and been sent back to Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate.

This Zhaoyao Assembly had encountered so many unexpected incidents that it was cut short halfway through. As a precaution, each sect sent their disciples back first, leaving only a few people at Zhaoyao Mountain to help deal with the completely collapsed Divine Meteorite and the demon clan infiltration incident.

The events at Zhaoyao Mountain quickly spread across the world. The supposedly very safe Zhaoyao Mountain had actually been infiltrated by demon clan members. The Zhaoyao Saintess was furious after coming out of seclusion, and all immortal sects were on high alert. For a time, everyone in the martial world felt insecure.

Ever since then, Ning Fuyi had become very drowsy, as if she had been exhausted for many days. After returning to Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate and hearing a general account of what happened, she fell into deep sleep again. This time she slept for three full days and nights before completely waking up.

When she awoke, it was already noon. The disciples had already gone to morning cultivation. She stared at the coffered ceiling for a long time before getting up in a daze. Ping An, who had been guarding by her bedside for a long time, barked and jumped into her arms, nearly knocking her back into dreamland.

"I was only gone for a few days, how did you get so much fatter again?" Ning Fuyi drowsily fumbled around Ping An's body. The little dog that had been skin and bones in her arms had now become plump and round—you could pinch three folds on its belly.

It really was popular with the young women. Ever since Ning Fuyi had left it to be raised in Pearl Radiance Pavilion, disciples came to feed it every day. Each time she went to pet it, its belly was stuffed round, so she didn't need to worry about it at all.

She petted Ping An's back repeatedly, her gaze fixed and vacant.

Having slept so long, the events in the Divine Meteorite felt like a dream. Although there was always a way out when you reached the mountain¹, she had thought she would surely die, yet somehow she had escaped. It still felt unbelievable.

Moreover, although the Emei Thorn had been taken by someone else, she had drawn the divine sword. It could be considered that what was lost was made up for elsewhere. She wondered what the divine sword had seen in her.

Just as Ning Fuyi thought of this, the divine sword emerged from her storage bead, standing at the foot of the bed and spinning, shining brilliantly.

Ning Fuyi extended her hand, and the divine sword suddenly bounced into her palm. The exquisite, translucent sword body swayed, about to nuzzle against her face. If Ning Fuyi hadn't dodged quickly, it might have sliced off her ear.

"Do you remember you're a divine sword? How are you even more clingy than Ping An?" Ning Fuyi said helplessly. As soon as she finished speaking, the divine sword switched to nuzzling her with its hilt, rubbing until her hair was completely disheveled. Seeing this, Ping An in her arms became unwilling and barked at the divine sword.

"Alright, alright." The room was suddenly in chaos. She was being nuzzled until her face hurt, dodging back and forth helplessly. Finally, she had to grab the sword hilt and forcibly throw it back into her storage bead, pushing Ping An off the bed as well.

Currently, apart from Chu Qingqiu, no one else knew she had drawn the divine sword. Better to avoid trouble—if she was exposed too early, it would inevitably attract covetous people.

She remembered again the demon who had specifically wanted to take her life in the Divine Meteorite. In her previous life, she had lived for a thousand years and never encountered this person. How was it that now, living again, an enemy had emerged from nowhere?

She needed to become stronger quickly. This person's power was unfathomable. If she encountered him again in the future without Chu Qingqiu's protection and good luck, she would inevitably suffer.

Thinking this, Ning Fuyi suddenly sat up cross-legged, formed seals with her hands at her chest, and when she opened them, clear pink light accumulated in her palms.

The moment she sensed the power within her body, Ning Fuyi's heart surged with wild joy. The long-missed satisfaction from power made her feel almost euphoric.

She remembered that after drawing the divine sword, she had felt abundant immortal energy within her body. She had thought it was just a fleeting moment, but now when she circulated her energy again, she discovered that her immortal energy seemed even more abundant.

She suddenly flicked out two fingers. The flower vase at the head of the opposite bed immediately shattered. When her fingers flicked back, it was restored to new.

Ning Fuyi sat in place rejoicing for a long time. She had never realized her desire to become stronger was so intense. Now, with just some progress, she was overjoyed.

When she recovered her previous life's strength, she would no longer have to hide behind others, nor would she lose those she loved.

Although it wasn't demonic power for now, as long as she wasn't a waste who couldn't cultivate, it was good news.

After thinking this through, she leaped down from the bed, feeling refreshed and energetic, her legs much stronger. Looking at the black clothes she was somehow wearing, she hesitated for a moment, then found the garment Chu Qingqiu had made for her and quickly put it on.

Clothes with immortal energy woven into the silk threads were indeed much more comfortable than ordinary clothes. She was no longer being stubborn with Chu Qingqiu—there was no need to make herself suffer.

Chu Qingqiu's appearance that day in the Divine Meteorite, barely clinging to life, was still vivid in her memory. She wondered how she was doing now. In the past, Ning Fuyi had always felt that Chu Qingqiu was an omnipotent existence like a deity, but after seeing her state in the Divine Meteorite, that feeling had faded.

Chu Qingqiu could also be hurt and feel pain, could feel joy and anger, like a portrait that had originally been colorless but was now gradually becoming rich and colorful.

Ning Fuyi knew her own weakness. Perhaps because too many people had been bad to her in her previous life while good people were few and far between, although she was sharp-tongued toward ordinary people, she could remember for a long time anyone who was good to her.

As for Chu Qingqiu... it was indeed complicated, but she could be certain that she seemed to no longer hate her as much.

Even in the Divine Meteorite, she had strongly hoped that Chu Qingqiu wouldn't die.

Or perhaps, she should go ask? After all, this wasn't anything embarrassing. The two of them had fought side by side once, so it was appropriate to inquire.

Ning Fuyi found enough reasons for herself, cleared her throat, put her hands behind her back, and prepared to go to Tranquil Mountain Palace. However, as soon as she walked out the door, she encountered disciples returning to rest. She felt their gazes upon her but didn't plan to acknowledge them, intending to brush past them sideways.

However, before she could walk down the steps, her sleeve was grabbed. She instinctively tried to pull away, but someone hooked her other elbow and practically hung on her, saying joyfully: "Young Sect Leader! When did you wake up? Why didn't you say anything before going out?"

Ning Fuyi recognized the voice of the female disciple with the sky-high ponytail. Today her ponytail was tied with green rope, swaying on top of her head like bundled straw. Ning Fuyi forcibly shifted her gaze away from the ponytail and coldly withdrew her arm: "Just woke up. I have urgent matters. I'll go first."

She was about to escape, but more and more disciples surrounded her, chattering about the events in the Divine Meteorite. Ning Fuyi couldn't handle so many people and was bodily carried back to Pearl Radiance Pavilion by the crowd.

"Young Sect Leader, I heard that among all the disciples who went to Zhaoyao Mountain, only you coincidentally followed the Divine Venerable into the Divine Meteorite. What kind of place is the Divine Meteorite? Are there really gods inside?" The female disciple immediately started talking as soon as she sat down, her eyes bright as she asked.

"These past few days, the elders have been busy sealing the mountain gate. There are rumors that demon clan members infiltrated Zhaoyao Mountain and disrupted the Zhaoyao Assembly, which is why they're taking precautions. But the elders won't let us discuss this matter. Young Sect Leader, please tell us about it!" People kept pestering Ning Fuyi, making her extremely annoyed. She wanted to lose her temper but held back, her face reddening from the suppression.

"Why aren't you resting during rest time? What are you all gathering here for?" Fortunately, a stern voice came from the doorway. The disciples immediately scattered like birds and beasts, finally freeing Ning Fuyi.

She frowned and rubbed her ears, then looked toward the main door. The person she saw made her stop in place, a blush rising on her face.

It was Feng Ge, who had just returned from Suspended Beam Garden. Li Zhao'an was beside her, wearing a bright yellow dress. She had been laughing and saying something, but when she saw Ning Fuyi, her expression immediately darkened.

She should have been the one selected for the Zhaoyao Assembly this year, but Ning Fuyi had stolen this opportunity from her.

Not only had Ning Fuyi defeated her to go to Zhaoyao Mountain, but she had also made such a big impression there. These past few days, everyone in the sect had been talking about it, making Li Zhao'an's teeth itch with anger every time she heard it.

So Li Zhao'an quickened her pace, stomping on the floor with loud thuds, forcefully slapping the book on immortal history she was carrying onto the table. Just as she was about to make some sarcastic remarks, she turned around to see something that made her blood boil even more.

Senior Sister Feng Ge, who had previously listened to many of her words and thus had quite an opinion of Ning Fuyi, was now carefully approaching that Ning Fuyi, speaking in low, caring tones.

She nearly ground her silver teeth to powder. Usually, all the senior brothers, sisters, and elders in the sect favored her, while Ning Fuyi was liked by no one except Ning Changfeng. She had always felt superior to Ning Fuyi because of this, but seeing this scene now, she felt as if those preferences were being stolen away.

She gloomily stared at the two, finally grabbing the book from the table and leaving angrily.

"Ning Fuyi, how is your health?" Feng Ge said somewhat awkwardly. She noticed Ning Fuyi rubbing her ears and quickly took out pills from her sleeve. "Are you still suffering from old injuries? I have some high-grade pills here, you..."

"No, no, no." Ning Fuyi quickly waved her hands. She wasn't used to such an abnormally acting Feng Ge. "I wasn't really injured to begin with, so I'm naturally fine."

"That's good." Feng Ge breathed a sigh of relief but still left the pills on the table, gripping the spiritual sword at her waist. "When we learned that you and the Divine Venerable were trapped in the Divine Meteorite, we were all extremely panicked. Fortunately, you both are safe, otherwise we wouldn't know how to live with ourselves."

"That day, thanks to you recognizing that they were possessed by demonic energy, you saved our lives. I used to listen to others' words and thought you were someone who took shortcuts and deliberately ignored you." Feng Ge's face was full of shame. "Now thinking about it, I was being petty. Since you're willing to risk your life to save fellow disciples, how could you have evil intentions?"

"Feng apologizes." Feng Ge was about to bow, but Ning Fuyi quickly stopped her.

Ning Fuyi had always been the one who was feared or despised by others. She could face malice calmly, but suddenly receiving such a sincere apology made her quite uncomfortable.

However, hearing kind words did improve her mood considerably, so although she hadn't intentionally saved them, she still straightened her back and said it was nothing.

"As long as you don't take it to heart." Feng Ge was relieved and maturely patted her shoulder. "The elder said you're fine, just that your immortal energy is somehow disordered, which is why you fell unconscious. You'll be fine when you wake up. But since you were exposed to demonic energy, if you feel any discomfort in the coming days, you must report it immediately."

Ning Fuyi nodded in agreement, and only then did Feng Ge take her leave.

Now with no one to obstruct her, Ning Fuyi finally had time to go to Tranquil Mountain Palace. However, just as she reached the entrance, she saw Qiu Yi hurriedly running out with a cloth bag, nearly falling flat on her face when Ning Fuyi grabbed her arm.

"Where is Chu... the Divine Venerable?" she asked.

Qiu Yi looked back irritably, and seeing it was Ning Fuyi, pushed her away with one hand: "Master isn't here. What are you doing here causing trouble? Go away, go away, I have urgent matters!"

As she spoke, she summoned her curved blade, stepped on it, and flew into the sky. Seeing that she wouldn't answer, Ning Fuyi deduced she was going to find Chu Qingqiu, so she took out the divine sword from her storage bead, lightly touched the ground with her toe, and soared through the gentle breeze.

She was already proficient in sword-riding techniques, but previously her cultivation was insufficient and she lacked suitable magical instruments, which was why she couldn't learn it. Now it was different—riding the divine sword felt natural, and she easily kept up with Qiu Yi.

She saw Qiu Yi fly down the mountain on her sword, stopping at the stone gate at the foot of Cloud Ascension Mountain, handing the cloth bag to someone.

That person was indeed Chu Qingqiu, standing gracefully in white robes under the gate. She took the bag with one hand, removed an exquisite pearl from it, and placed it on a tray. From her appearance, she seemed to be waiting for someone.

Judging from her upright posture, she should have recovered some strength and showed no signs of being injured.

Ning Fuyi put away her divine sword from a distance, hiding behind a pine tree and landing silently. She didn't know there was still someone in this world who could make Chu Qingqiu wait.

And she had even prepared generous gifts. Chu Qingqiu, someone who avoided worldly affairs, usually never bothered with such considerations.

As she was thinking, a ray of sunset suddenly appeared in the sky. When the light came closer, she could see it was a person riding on orange-yellow auspicious clouds, wearing plain clothes with an evening-glow colored shawl draped over her arms, swaying in the wind.

That person was beautiful and dignified, especially her eyes which sparkled brilliantly. She landed gracefully like ripples on water, walked a few steps slowly, and bowed to Chu Qingqiu.

Chu Qingqiu handed her the pearl. After receiving it, she smiled and said something, then suddenly grasped Chu Qingqiu's hand and slowly caressed it.

Ning Fuyi's ears immediately emitted a puff of hot air. She watched coldly, feeling inexplicably indignant. She hadn't expected that Chu Qingqiu, who seemed like a crane in the clouds, would secretly pluck earthly flowers².

And that woman—getting handsy in broad daylight—was definitely not a good person. She really wanted to...

However, before this thought could form completely, the divine sword in her storage bead understood her intentions, flashed past like wind, and struck the woman's forehead hard with its hilt. The woman flew into the roadside grass before she could even retract her smile.

Chu Qingqiu's hand was still extended in mid-air. She paused silently for a moment, then looked toward Ning Fuyi's direction.

Footnotes:

¹ **"There's always a way out when you reach the mountain"** (车到山前必有路) - A Chinese idiom meaning that solutions will present themselves when the time comes.

² **"Plucking earthly flowers"** - A poetic way of saying someone is engaging in romantic affairs or relationships, contrasting with Chu Qingqiu's otherworldly, aloof nature.